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Theory

THIS BOOK delves into a pressing question for global governance: How do IOs respond to populist challenges, and what are the broader implications of their actions? In addressing this question, we tackle other theoretically significant puzzles, such as why some states receive special concessions from IOs while others are held to strict standards, why IOs sometimes collaborate but at other times compete, and how they navigate the balance between transparency and secrecy. We also explore when and why IOs reach out to domestic audiences and the messages they choose to communicate.

At the heart of our analysis lies a simple yet critical assertion: IOs are not merely passive players in the international arena. Instead, they are strategic agents that actively shape global governance, especially when confronted with existential threats like populism. By focusing on IOs' capacity to push back against opposition, we reveal how these institutions defend their mandates, adapt to challenges, and evolve to meet the demands of a shifting global landscape.

While IOs may use these strategies to counter other adversarial actors, populists present a particularly formidable and sustained challenge. As discussed in the introduction, populism poses a credible, large-scale threat to IOs because of its ideological opposition to global governance and its ability to mobilize domestic support. Unlike transient or isolated challenges, populism represents a structural challenge to the liberal international order.